

Next Gen Fire Action Assessment (FAA)

Plain-language overview

Northwoods FAA

2026-07-23

Region: Northern Michigan, Wisconsin, and Minnesota's Arrowhead

Audience: Leaders, partners, and land managers who need to develop a shared picture of *what to do where* — without needing GIS or modeling expertise

Goals

Wildfire work will always cost more time, money, and political capital than we have. The Fire Action Assessment (FAA) helps partners answer a practical question:

Where should our efforts go first, and what kind of work makes sense there?

Goals of this effort:

- **Facilitate conversations**, not close them. The map is a structured starting point for agencies, tribes, counties, industry, and communities — not a verdict.
- **Talk about actions**, not “good” vs “bad” ecosystems or landscapes. A place is not scored as worthy or unworthy; it is labeled with a *suggested focus* (protect an asset, work near people, restore fire-adapted systems, assess wetlands carefully, or wait and watch).
- **Stay strategic**. Hexes are large (~10,000 acres). Think “where to look harder and talk next,” not “cut or burn this stand tomorrow.”
- **Use existing, trusted data wisely** — [community wildfire risk](#) products, landscape wildfire exposure risk, [LANDFIRE](#) ecosystems and disturbance data, and (soon) recent disturbance maps — combined in a way people can understand and adjust.
- **Keep every rule visible and reproducible**. Logic lives in plain documents anyone can review and code analysts can re-run, and adapt for another area of interest.
- **Leave room for local knowledge**. This is not NEPA, not broad stakeholder consultation, and not a prescription. Managers still decide based on access, markets, smoke, values, and on-the-ground conditions.

What is innovative here

Most maps stop at **risk** (where something bad *could* happen). FAA goes one step further: it proposes an **action class** on every place and a **manageable priority band** so programs aren't asked to "fix everything red."

Innovation	Why it matters
Actions, not only heat maps	Partners can discuss <i>protect, treat for people, ecosystem health, wetlands assess</i> , or <i>defer</i> — a shared vocabulary for meetings.
People and ecosystems in one frame	Homes and fire-adapted forests both matter; rules say when people come first and when ecosystem work is the focus.
More than one hazard signal	Today's exposure map, ecological fire dependence, and recent fuel-adding events (insects, ice, wind) each catch situations the others miss.
"Goldilocks" priorities	Among places where we'd <i>do something</i> , flag a top slice so leaders can size a realistic near-term footprint.
Documented + coded	Same rules every time; change a weight or a threshold on purpose, not by accident in a one-off GIS session.
Built to travel	Swap the boundary, hexes, and local data; keep the method — useful beyond this one project.

The idea in one sentence

We combine **today's fire hazard, whether the land is naturally fire-adapted, recent fuel-loading events, and people and homes** — then assign a simple action and rank the places that matter most under a people-first lens.

We look at...	In plain terms	Real-world example
Wildfire exposure	Where fire can carry and behave severely <i>today</i>	Continuous jack pine that shows up "hot" on the exposure map
Fire-adapted ecology	Where ecosystems historically needed fire — even if today's hazard map looks quieter	Red pine or barrens the exposure map may under-emphasize
Recent disturbances	Where insects, ice, or wind <i>added</i> fuels that older hazard maps miss	Arrowhead insect mortality; lower Michigan ice/wind blowdown

We look at...	In plain terms	Real-world example
People (community risk)	Where housing and community wildfire risk are high	Town edges, lake-home clusters, WUI
Special cases	Plantations (timber assets) and peat/wetlands (need a local call)	Tree farm; large peatland complex

Ownership maps and mills can inform *feasibility* later; they do not pick the action in this version.

How actions are assigned (with examples)

Each hexagon gets **one primary action** (simple rules, applied in order). These are **working hypotheses for discussion**, not orders.

1. **Protect from fire** — Keep damaging fire *out* of a high-value asset (especially **plantations**). Tools are often thinning or harvest; prescribed fire is not the main goal.
Example: A managed pine plantation — protect the timber investment.
2. **Wetlands — assess locally** — Peat and similar wetlands can be fire-related *and* extremely hard to control once they burn. The map flags them; people with local hydrology and fire history decide.
Example: A large bog with limited access — don't auto-ignore and don't auto-burn; put it on the conversation list.
3. **Treat fire risk for people** — High hazard **and/or** recent fuel buildup **near homes**. Emphasis: mechanical fuels work plus home hardening / defensible space — not lighting fire near communities.
Example A: High exposure next to community.
Example B: Modeled exposure looks modest, but a recent ice storm left heavy fuels beside those homes — still a “people” conversation.
4. **Ecosystem health focus** — Fire-adapted country **away from dense housing**, where beneficial or prescribed fire (sometimes after thinning) is the point.
Example A: Jack pines far from town — restore fire as a process.
Example B: Red pine that isn't the “hottest” on the hazard map but is fire-adapted — still a candidate for ecosystem work, not “nothing to see here.”
5. **Defer / monitor** — Low stakes for now: little hazard, little recent fuel add, not a special asset. **Defer is not a value judgment** — it means “not the near-term treatment conversation.”
Example: Mesic northern hardwoods with low exposure and no major recent disturbance.

A short “**how**” **note** may sit beside the action (e.g., silviculture for plantations; fuels + home hardening near people). That is a hint for discussion, not a second ranking system.

How prioritization works (“Goldilocks”)

We cannot treat everything. Among places where the map says **do something** (not defer), we score urgency with a **people-first** lens: homes and community risk weigh most, then fire hazard; plantations also count. Leaders then see a **manageable band**, not an endless red map:

Priority	Rough meaning
3	Top ~5% of actionable places — start here for near-term planning talks
2	Top ~10%
1	Top ~15%
0	Actionable but outside that near-term band, or deferred

Example: A peatland next to high community risk can still rise in priority — it needs a careful local call *and* may be urgent. A quiet hardwood block does not crowd the short list.

Different partners can later emphasize plantations or other values; the default shared view stays people-first so the first conversation is coherent.

How to use this

- **Leaders & non-technical partners:** Use actions + priority bands to set the agenda (“these are the first places we need a joint conversation”). Challenge and rewrite rules when local reality disagrees — that is success, not failure.
- **Land managers:** Treat the action as a hypothesis. Ground-truth; adjust for access, markets, smoke, wildlife, cultural resources, and capacity.
- **Analysts & future projects:** Re-run the same coded steps when data improve (better plantations, fresher disturbances). Document any rule change so last year’s map and this year’s map stay comparable.

Bottom line: FAA is a **conversation tool** built on **smart reuse of existing data**, with **actions instead of good/bad labels**, and **open, reproducible rules** — so Northwoods partners can focus scarce wildfire effort where it matters most, together.